

Trump’s reversals propel markets

President backpedals on China tariffs and firing Fed chair after CEOs warn of stores facing shortages soon.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration is looking for an offramp from the trade war it started with China this month, calling its tariffs on Chinese goods unsustainable as major retailers warn the White House that U.S. consumers will begin seeing supply shortages and higher prices within weeks.

Markets initially soared on remarks from President Trump and his Treasury secretary, Scott Bessent, acknowledging the current tariff rate of 145% on China will have to come down “substantially.” But subsequent comments from the White House on Wednesday, that the administration would not lower the rate without reciprocal action from Beijing, cooled enthusiasm on Wall Street.

At the closing bell, the Dow Jones industrial average was up 419 points, or about 1%, while the Nasdaq composite and the Standard & Poor’s 500 index were up 2.5% and 1.67%, respectively.

“There will be no unilateral reduction in tariffs against China,” Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, told Fox News in an interview Wednesday afternoon. “The president has made it clear that China needs to make a deal with the United States of America.”

It is unclear whether China will cooperate, however, when it sees pain setting in first for American households, which could maximize its leverage in trade negotiations. Caillan Press, a Chinese media outlet focused on finance, characterized the administration’s latest rhetoric as “a sign that Trump is already softening stance on his signature tariff policies.”

On Wednesday, Trump told reporters that talks [See **White House**, A4]

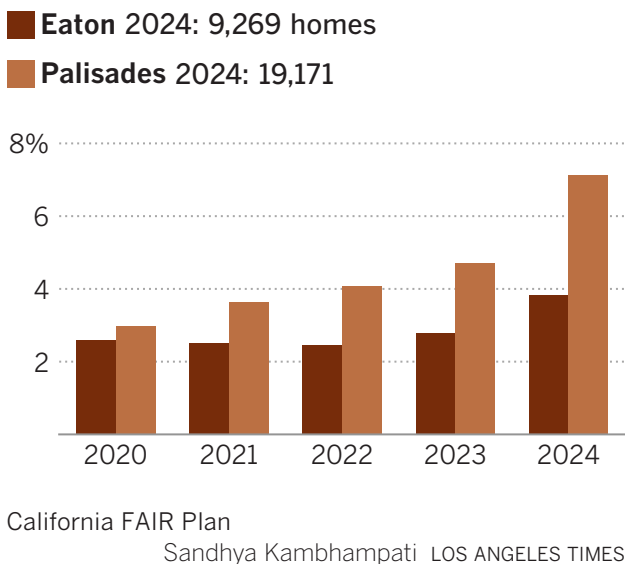


ERIC THAYER For The Times

DIANE HVOLKA is waiting for a \$550,000 check from the FAIR Plan that was promised in February. “This is so frustrating,” she said.

Dependence on state for insurance has increased in fire areas

Share of households on FAIR Plan



Relying on last-resort insurer, and regretting

State’s FAIR Plan saw surge in recent years. Fire victims struggle now to get payouts.

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO AND SANDHYA KAMBHAMPATI

When Diane Hvolka’s home burned down in January, the real estate attorney didn’t lose just her Pacific Palisades residence but a link to her teenage daughter, who died two years ago. The tragic loss of her only

child — whose room she had left untouched — has left her determined to rebuild on her Glenhaven Drive property. But so far, Hvolka said, she’s been stymied by the California FAIR Plan, from which she bought coverage last year after her insurer of more than a decade suddenly dropped her.

“I want to be on the land where my daughter grew up,” said Hvolka, 47, who said she was promised a \$550,000 check from the insurer in early February that has yet to arrive. “This is so frustrating. I’ve been chasing them ever since.”

That Hvolka had to buy a

policy from the state’s troubled home insurer of last resort after losing her insurance was hardly unusual, according to a Times analysis of FAIR Plan and California Department of Insurance data.

The Times found that in the Palisades and Eaton fire zones, the FAIR Plan’s rolls shot up last year a combined 47%. From 2020 to 2024, the number of homes in both areas on the plan nearly doubled from 14,272 to 28,440.

That exceeded, according to the Times analysis, a 40% growth in policies is [See **FAIR Plan**, A12]

Arrests at Home Depot in Pomona spark fear of labor crackdown

By CLARA HARTER, ANTHONY SOLORZANO, NATHAN SOLIS AND HANNAH FRY

A U.S. Customs and Border Protection raid at a Home Depot in Pomona has heightened concerns over the Trump administration’s

targeting of immigrant workers and its potential to stymie rebuilding efforts after Los Angeles County’s devastating January firestorms.

Unmarked vehicles were the first to arrive outside the Home Depot on South Towne Avenue in Pomona around 8:30 a.m. Tuesday,

where dozens of workers had gathered outside, according to witnesses and advocates.

An official with the Department of Homeland Security said 10 people were arrested in the enforcement action. Immigration advocates had previously estimated that as many as 25 were arrested.

Community members previously said the raid was carried out by Immigration and Customs Enforcement, but ICE officials said the agency did not participate in the activity and directed questions to U.S. Customs and Border Protection. A senior Department of Homeland Security official

said in a statement to The Times that agents conducted an operation Tuesday targeting an individual with an active arrest warrant.

“During the operation, nine additional illegal aliens were encountered and taken into custody. Several of [See **Raid**, A6]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

THE AHMANSON hosts “Shrek the Musical Jr.” with Jolie Simmons, left, Dylan Hunt and Journee Everly, after Eliot Arts Magnet’s theater burned in Altadena.

COLUMN ONE

A community rallies around theater kids and fire survivors for their musical night

By JESSICA GELT

This is a story about 60 kids who lost their homes, their theater, their whole neighborhoods to the Eaton fire as it raged

through Altadena on a ferociously windy night one week into the new year.

For the students of Altadena Arts Magnet and Eliot Arts Magnet schools, however, the story does not end there. Because in a remarkable display of community spirit, these kids became

the characters of a different drama — this one about young survivors who, determined to carry on their spring musical, channel their loss into a one-night-only, sold-out performance of “Shrek the Musical Jr.” on one of L.A.’s most prestigious [See **Students**, A9]

Chainsawed trees deal another blow to L.A.’s struggling downtown

An arrest has been made, but the blatant vandalism reignites concerns about the city core’s decline.

By GRACE TOOHEY

Downtown Los Angeles has seen more than its share of indignity over the last few years.

The pandemic sent office vacancy rates rising as masses of in-person workers stayed home, and, in turn, many restaurants and businesses shuttered. Homelessness soared amid interconnected economic, mental health and drug crises.

And though downtown has since seen some development, a looming sense of disarray and decline lingers. After the 6th Street Viaduct was triumphantly unveiled,

its hype quickly gave way to unruly street takeovers and copper thieves wire-stripping its lighting.

Even as the skyline expanded, Angelinos’ attention fell on two skyscrapers that taggers had almost entirely covered in graffiti.

Which is why the recent shocking act of vandalism that took out more than a dozen of the city’s mature trees, mainly downtown, felt all the more disheartening.

“This has struck a chord,” said Cassidy Horton, a 37-year-old downtown resident. “It just really like flies in the face of everything that we’re trying to do [to revitalize] the community, and for somebody to go around ... and set back what little progress we already have ... was really, really upsetting and hurtful.”

Along with safety, she said, green space has been one of the top concerns of [See **Trees**, A6]

Kyiv prolonging war, Trump says

Ukraine’s president has pushed back on calls to cede Crimea and other territory to Russia. **WORLD, A3**

L.A. is nation’s smoggiest city

American Lung Assn. report says despite improvements, it ranks at top for 25th time. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Kings’ Game 2 coverage online

Wednesday night’s Western Conference first-round game ended after this edition’s deadline. For full coverage, go to **latimes.com/sports**.

Weather

Morning low clouds. L.A. Basin: 69/54. **B6**

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